DECODE UPSC with Mounika

The El Niño Squeeze

Drought · Onions · the RBI Hike · Your Right to the Internet · India–NZ Trade Deal

Week 43 · Coverage 19–25 Oct 2026, with key carry-over from earlier in October · Video released Tue 27 Oct 2026

Useful for: **UPSC CSE Prelims 2027** · **UPSC Mains (GS 1–4, Essay)** · **APPSC / TGPSC Group-1**

How to use these notes

- **Watch the video first, then read these notes.** Each pillar has five parts: Why in news → Static anchor → Prelims traps → Mains dimensions → Way forward.
- **Prelims:** attempt the 10 MCQs *before* checking the answer key at the end.
- **Mains:** write at least one of the four answers this week, using the skeleton given.
- Facts are current as of **26 Oct 2026**. Always confirm figures against official sources (IMD, MoSPI, RBI, Supreme Court, PIB) before quoting them in an exam.

Pillar 1 — The El Niño Drought **GS-1 · GS-3 · Group-1**

Why in news

- The southwest monsoon **withdrew from the entire country on 15 Oct 2026**. It ended about **13% below the long period average (LPA)**, roughly 87% of LPA.
- **Andhra Pradesh** declared **388 mandals in 21 of its 28 districts** drought-hit for Kharif 2026: **283 severe, 105 moderate** (order dated 1 Oct 2026).
- AP's June–August rainfall was about **53% below normal**.
- **Marathwada** ended the season more than a third below normal.
- **IIT Gandhinagar's India Drought Monitor**, as reported by Down To Earth, at one point showed over **70% of India's land** as dry or in drought.
- For comparison, **1987 and 2002**, two of the worst drought years, each ended about **19%** short.

Static anchor

- **El Niño:** abnormal warming of the central and eastern equatorial Pacific. It weakens the Walker circulation and is linked to a weaker Indian monsoon.
- **Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD):** a *positive* IOD (warmer western Indian Ocean) can offset El Niño. *Example:* 1997 was a strong El Niño year, yet rainfall was near-normal.
- **IMD all-India seasonal categories (% of LPA):**

Deficient	Below normal	Normal	Above normal	Excess
< 90	90–95	96–104	105–110	> 110

- **Sub-division scale is different:** for a single meteorological sub-division, "normal" is −19% to +19%. Telangana's −17% therefore still counts as *normal*.
- **Who declares drought:** the **state government**, following the *Manual for Drought Management* (first issued 2009, revised 2016 after a Supreme Court order, updated 2020).
- **How the manual works:** rainfall indicators come first, then impact indicators (sown area, satellite vegetation indices, soil moisture, reservoirs, groundwater), then field verification.
- **Relief:** the **SDRF**, topped up by the **NDRF** for severe calamities, under the **Disaster Management Act, 2005**.
- **Nodal ministry for drought:** the **Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare**, not the MHA.

Prelims traps

1. ❌ "IMD declares drought." ✅ IMD only classifies rainfall. **States declare drought.**
2. ❌ "MHA is the nodal ministry for all disasters." ✅ For **drought** it is **Agriculture & Farmers Welfare**.
3. ❌ "87% of LPA is 'below normal'." ✅ It is **deficient**. Below normal is 90–95%.
4. ❌ "El Niño always means a deficient monsoon." ✅ A **positive IOD** can offset it (1997).
5. ❌ "−17% in a sub-division is deficient." ✅ For a sub-division, normal is **±19%**.

Mains dimensions

Economic & Fiscal	Governance & Federal	Security & Geopolitics	Socio-Environmental
Kharif losses (pulses, oilseeds, groundnut) feed food inflation (see Pillar 2); rural demand falls; strain on SDRF	States declare, but money follows central norms, so states may hesitate. *Swaraj Abhiyan v. UoI* (2016) criticised states' reluctance to declare drought	Water stress sharpens inter-state river disputes; food stocks shape export curbs	Distress migration, fodder shortage, falling groundwater, women walking further for water

Way forward

- ***Swaraj Abhiyan v. UoI* (2016):** the Court directed an updated drought manual, a **National Disaster Mitigation Fund**, and early, honest declarations.
- **Mihir Shah Committee (2016):** merge the CWC and CGWB into a single **National Water Commission**, shifting focus from building dams to managing aquifers and demand.
- **PMKSY "Per Drop More Crop"** micro-irrigation, plus crop diversification away from paddy in rain-shadow zones.
- Move from **relief to resilience**: risk-based financing and early declarations.

> **Telugu States Lens (APPSC / TGPSC Group-1)**
>
> - AP's 388 mandals were judged on rainfall *plus* dry spells, reservoirs, groundwater, soil moisture and vegetation. That is the drought manual in action.
> - **Rayalaseema**, especially undivided **Anantapur** district, is AP's most drought-prone belt.
> - **Telangana** ended about 17% short, which is still "normal" on the sub-division scale. The relevant state programme to cite is **Mission Kakatiya** (tank restoration).
> - *Use in:* the Group-1 Mains paper on economy and development.

Pillar 2 — The Rate Hike GS-3

Why in news

- **September 2026 CPI inflation: 5.54%**, up from **4.83%** in August.
  - Food inflation: **7.74%** (from 5.97%).
  - Rural **6.08%**, urban **4.88%**.
  - Onion prices more than doubled year on year (+108%).
  - Released 12 Oct 2026; new CPI series with **base year 2024**.
- **RBI MPC (5–7 Oct 2026):** repo rate raised **25 bps, from 5.25% to 5.50%**.
  - The **rate vote was 6–0**.
  - The stance moved from neutral to **"calibrated tightening"** (as reported) on a **4–2** vote.
  - **SDF 5.25%, MSF 5.75%.**
  - This is the **first hike since February 2023**.

Static anchor: RBI Act, 1934 (amended 2016)

Section	What it says
45ZA	The **Central Government**, in consultation with the RBI, sets the inflation target every 5 years. The target is **4% CPI ± 2%**, **renewed on 25 Mar 2026 for 2026–31**
45ZB	Constitutes the **Monetary Policy Committee**: 6 members, 3 from the RBI (Governor chairs) and 3 external members appointed by the Centre
45ZI	MPC meetings and voting. On a **tie, the Governor has a second or casting vote**
45ZN	If the RBI **fails the target**, it must report the reasons and remedial action to the government. *Failure* is defined by the Centre's 2016 notification as average inflation outside 2–6% for **3 consecutive quarters**

- **Urjit Patel Committee (2014)** recommended flexible inflation targeting.
- **Liquidity Adjustment Facility (LAF) corridor:** the floor is the **SDF**, used since 2022 and needing no collateral. The ceiling is the **MSF**.

Prelims traps

1. ❌ "The RBI sets the inflation target." ✅ The **Central Government** does (s.45ZA).
2. ❌ "The MPC decides CRR and SLR." ✅ The MPC fixes **only the policy repo rate**.
3. ❌ "All MPC members are RBI officials." ✅ **Three are external**, appointed by the Centre.
4. ❌ "The reverse repo is the floor of the corridor." ✅ Since 2022 it has been the **SDF**.
5. ❌ "CPI is compiled by the RBI." ✅ By the **NSO under MoSPI**.

Mains dimensions

Economic & Fiscal	Governance & Federal	Security & Geopolitics	Socio-Environmental
The repo rate is a demand tool, but this is a supply shock (drought, onion, crude). The hike aims to anchor **expectations** and stop **second-round effects**. Costs: higher EMIs, costlier MSME credit, slower growth	MPC independence: the 4–2 split shows open debate. Supply-side tools sit with the government	Crude oil and a weaker rupee import inflation	Inflation is a regressive tax: rural (6.08%) is above urban (4.88%). The drought taxes the poor twice

Way forward

- Supply-side tools: the **Price Stabilisation Fund**, onion buffer stocks, **Operation Greens (TOP: tomato, onion, potato)**, and cold chains.
- **Coordination:** the RBI anchors expectations; the government fixes supply.
- **Link to Pillar 1:** drought-proofing agriculture is also anti-inflation policy.

> **Telugu States Lens: Kurnool** is AP's onion heartland. When prices swing, its farmers feel the crash and its shoppers feel the spike.

Pillar 3 — Internet as a Fundamental Right, for Children Too GS-2 · GS-4

Why in news

- ***Just Rights for Children Alliance v. S. Harish***, judgment dated **15 Oct 2026**, by Justices **J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran**.

- **Holding:** the right to access and use the internet is a fundamental right of **every individual, including children**, under **Article 21 read with Article 19(1)(a)**.
- **No blanket age bans.** The Court suggested proportionate safeguards instead: parental consent, a child mode, and private accounts by default. Modalities are left to the Union.
- The State may still block **inherently harmful content**, such as adult sites.
- **CSEAM directions:**
  - a **National Hash and URL List Database**, with entries checked by trained human analysts
  - quick takedown of matching content
  - the Union to consider exemplary fines
- *Our analysis:* age-verification systems that collect sensitive data can create new **privacy risks**.

Static anchor: the case timeline

Year	Case	Holding
2017	*K.S. Puttaswamy*	Privacy is a fundamental right; proportionality test
2019	*Faheema Shirin* (Kerala HC)	Internet access linked to the right to education (Art 21)
2020	*Anuradha Bhasin*	Speech and trade **through the internet** protected under Art 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g); shutdowns must be necessary and proportionate
2024 (Sep)	*Just Rights for Children Alliance*	Viewing or storing CSEAM can attract **POCSO** and the **IT Act**; Court urged the term **CSEAM**
2025	*Pragya Prasun v. UoI*	**Digital access** is part of the right to life under **Art 21**
Oct 2026	*Just Rights for Children Alliance* (judgment)	Right to **access and use** the internet, including for children

- **DPDP Act, 2023:**
  - A **child is below 18**.
  - **Section 9** requires verifiable parental consent to process a child's data. This applies from about **May 2027**, 18 months after the DPDP Rules, 2025 were notified.
- **Nodal ministries:** POCSO is with the **Ministry of Women & Child Development**; the IT Act and DPDP Act are with **MeitY**.

Prelims traps

1. ❌ "*Anuradha Bhasin* declared internet access a fundamental right." ✅ It protected rights exercised **through the medium** of the internet.
2. ❌ "The Oct 2026 judgment guarantees free internet for all." ✅ It is about **access and proportionate safeguards**. It does not, by itself, promise free internet.
3. ❌ "Under the DPDP Act, a child is below 16." ✅ Below **18**.
4. ❌ "POCSO is administered by MeitY." ✅ By the **Ministry of Women & Child Development**.

Mains dimensions

Economic & Fiscal	Governance & Federal	Security & Geopolitics	Socio-Environmental
Education, DBT and UPI depend on access; platforms bear compliance costs	The Court sets the principle and leaves design to the executive, respecting the separation of powers. Fits with DPDP s.9	CSEAM crosses borders; hash databases detect known material automatically	Digital divide by gender and geography; age-verification privacy risks

GS-4 lens: paternalism vs. autonomy. *"Protection that removes the right to explore is not protection — it is confinement."* Prefer proportionality and safety-by-design over prohibition.

Way forward

- ***Justice B.N. Srikrishna Committee (2018)*** proposed special duties ("guardian data fiduciaries") for platforms handling children's data.
- A **safety-by-design** code for platforms instead of blanket bans.
- Amend POCSO terminology to **CSEAM**, as the Court recommended in 2024.
- **Privacy-preserving age assurance.**
- Close the access gap through **BharatNet** and **PM-WANI** public Wi-Fi.

Pillar 4 — India–New Zealand FTA: Trade Without Dairy

GS-2 · GS-3

Why in news

- **In force: 20 Oct 2026.** Signed **27 Apr 2026** in New Delhi; New Zealand passed its implementing law in **September 2026**.
- **Market access:** Indian exports get **duty-free access on all of New Zealand's tariff lines**. India offers concessions on about **70%** of its own lines.
- New Zealand commits to facilitating about **USD 20 billion** of investment.
- **Excluded:** milk, cream, whey, yogurt, cheese, onions, chickpeas, peas, almonds, sugar.
- **Apples, kiwifruit and manuka honey** get **lower duties only within fixed tariff-rate quotas**, and face **minimum import prices**. This protects growers in Himachal and Kashmir.

Static anchor

- **RCEP:** India **walked out in Nov 2019**, with fear of dairy import surges among the reasons. **New Zealand is an RCEP member.**
- **India's recent trade agreements:**
  - **Australia** ECTA (in force Dec 2022)
  - **EFTA** TEPA (in force Oct 2025; members **Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, Switzerland**; USD 100 bn investment commitment)
  - **UK** CETA (signed July 2025)
- **WTO legality:** FTAs are permitted under **GATT Art XXIV** (goods) and **GATS Art V** (services).
- **Negotiator:** the **Department of Commerce, Ministry of Commerce & Industry**.

Prelims traps

1. ❌ "The MEA negotiates trade agreements." ✅ The **Department of Commerce**.
2. ❌ "EFTA is part of the EU." ✅ It is **not**.
3. ❌ "India is an RCEP member." ✅ India **withdrew in 2019**; NZ is a member.
4. ❌ "A tariff-rate quota is an import ban." ✅ It means a **lower duty inside the quota** and a higher duty above it.
5. ❌ "FTAs violate WTO rules." ✅ They are allowed under **GATT Art XXIV / GATS Art V**.

Mains dimensions

Economic & Fiscal	Governance & Federal	Security & Geopolitics	Socio-Environmental
Access for labour-intensive exports (textiles, engineering, pharma); investment; low revenue risk	Agriculture is a State subject, but treaties use Union executive power without parliamentary ratification. *Debate:* is more parliamentary scrutiny needed?	The government presents each deal as a signal that India is a reliable partner after RCEP; supply-chain diversification; Pacific outreach	Dairy exclusion protects smallholder and women's livelihoods

Way forward

- Describe the model as **“guarded openness”**: red lines, plus TRQs and minimum import prices instead of all-or-nothing choices. It answers the concerns India itself raised when it left RCEP in 2019 (protecting farmers and small industry).
- Give MSMEs **rules-of-origin support** so they can actually claim the lower duties.
- Use the deal as a template for larger negotiations.

Prelims Practice — 10 MCQs

Attempt all ten before looking at the answer key.

Q1. With reference to drought management in India, consider the following statements:

1. The India Meteorological Department declares drought in districts.
2. The Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare is the nodal ministry for drought.
3. Drought is a notified calamity for assistance from the State Disaster Response Fund.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

Q2. If all-India southwest monsoon rainfall for a season is 87% of the Long Period Average, IMD classifies it as:

(a) Below normal
(b) Deficient
(c) Normal
(d) Scanty

Q3. Consider the following statements:

Statement-I: El Niño years always produce a deficient Indian monsoon.
Statement-II: A positive Indian Ocean Dipole can counteract the effect of El Niño on the Indian monsoon.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I
(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I
(c) Statement-I is correct but Statement-II is incorrect
(d) Statement-I is incorrect but Statement-II is correct

Q4. With reference to the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) under the RBI Act, 1934, consider the following statements:

1. The inflation target is determined by the Central Government in consultation with the RBI.
2. All six members of the MPC are appointed by the Reserve Bank of India.
3. In the event of a tie, the Governor has a second or casting vote.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

Q5. At present, the floor of the RBI’s Liquidity Adjustment Facility corridor is the:

(a) Reverse repo rate
(b) Bank rate
(c) Standing Deposit Facility rate
(d) Marginal Standing Facility rate

Q6. Consider the following pairs:

Index	Compiled by
1. CPI (Combined)	National Statistics Office, MoSPI
2. CPI for Industrial Workers	Labour Bureau
3. Wholesale Price Index	Office of the Economic Adviser, DPIIT

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

Q7. Consider the following statements:

Statement-I: In *Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India* (2020), the Supreme Court declared the right to access the internet itself to be a fundamental right.
Statement-II: The Court held that freedom of speech and expression, and of trade, through the medium of the internet enjoys constitutional protection under Article 19.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I
(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I
(c) Statement-I is correct but Statement-II is incorrect
(d) Statement-I is incorrect but Statement-II is correct

Q8. Consider the following statements:

1. Under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, a “child” means a person who has not completed eighteen years of age.
2. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 is administered by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology.
3. The nodal ministry for the POCSO Act, 2012 is the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

Q9. Consider the following countries:

1. Iceland
2. Liechtenstein
3. Norway
4. Denmark
5. Austria

How many of the above are members of the European Free Trade Association (EFTA)?

(a) Only two
(b) Only three
(c) Only four
(d) All five

Q10. Consider the following statements:

1. India is a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP).
2. Article XXIV of GATT permits free trade areas as an exception to most-favoured-nation treatment.

3. Under a tariff-rate quota, imports within the quota attract a lower tariff than imports above it.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

(a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

Mains Practice — 4 Questions

M1. GS-3 · 15 marks · 250 words "A modest national rainfall deficit can conceal a severe regional drought." Examine with reference to the 2026 monsoon, and suggest how India's drought governance can shift from relief to resilience.

- *Intro:* the 13% national deficit vs. AP's −53% (June–August) and 388 drought mandals.
- *Body:* why averages mislead (spatial and temporal spread, dry spells, groundwater); institutional gaps (state reluctance, *Swaraj Abhiyan*, SDRF norms); resilience tools (multi-indicator manual, PMKSY, crop diversification).
- *Conclusion:* the Mihir Shah shift from dams to demand; risk-based disaster financing.

M2. GS-3 · 10 marks · 150 words Can monetary tightening control inflation driven by supply shocks? Discuss with reference to the RBI's October 2026 policy.

- *Intro:* the 25 bps hike to 5.50%; September CPI 5.54%, food 7.74%.
- *Body:* limits of the rate tool (onion, drought, crude); why the RBI still acted (expectations, second-round effects, credibility of flexible inflation targeting).
- *Conclusion:* supply-side fixes (PSF, Operation Greens, buffer stocks) and fiscal–monetary coordination.

M3. GS-2 · 15 marks · 250 words The Supreme Court has recognised the right to access and use the internet as a fundamental right, including for children, while rejecting blanket age-based bans. Critically examine how the State can balance child safety with digital freedom.

- *Intro:* the 15 Oct 2026 judgment and the line of cases from *Bhasin* to *Pragya Prasun*.
- *Body:* rights basis (Arts 21, 19(1)(a)); risks (CSEAM, data, online harm); proportionate tools (consent, child mode, hash database, DPDP s.9); separation-of-powers concerns.
- *Conclusion:* safety-by-design over prohibition; the Srikrishna Committee's approach.

M4. GS-2 · 10 marks · 150 words India's FTA with New Zealand reflects a shift from defensive to guarded trade engagement. Discuss with reference to India's withdrawal from RCEP.

- *Intro:* in force 20 Oct 2026; the dairy red line.
- *Body:* why India left RCEP (dairy, agriculture, small industry); how this deal answers those concerns (exclusions, TRQs, minimum import prices); the gains (market access, investment).
- *Conclusion:* the remaining risks (low FTA utilisation, parliamentary scrutiny) and a template for future deals.

This Week's MCQ Challenge (answer in the pinned comment)

The answer is revealed in Sunday's video (1 Nov 2026).

Under which provision can a candidate be prosecuted for filing false information in an election affidavit, and what is the maximum punishment?

(a) Section 123 of the RP Act, 1951; up to 2 years
(b) Section 125A of the RP Act, 1951; up to 6 months, or fine, or both
(c) Section 8 of the RP Act, 1951; disqualification for 6 years
(d) Article 102 of the Constitution; disqualification only

Answer Key & Explanations

Q	Ans	Explanation
1	**(b)**	Statement 1 is wrong: IMD only classifies rainfall, and **state governments** declare drought under the drought manual. Statements 2 and 3 are correct.
2	**(b)**	Below 90% of LPA is **deficient**. Below normal is 90–95%; normal is 96–104%.
3	**(d)**	El Niño does not *always* cause a deficit: in 1997, a strong El Niño year, a positive IOD helped deliver near-normal rain. Statement-II is correct.
4	**(b)**	Statement 1 is correct (s.45ZA). Statement 2 is wrong: three members are external, appointed by the Centre. Statement 3 is correct (s.45ZI).
5	**(c)**	Since April 2022, the **Standing Deposit Facility** is the floor; the MSF is the ceiling.
6	**(c)**	All three pairs are correctly matched.
7	**(d)**	*Bhasin* did not decide whether internet access itself is a fundamental right. It protected speech and trade **through** the internet under Art 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g).
8	**(b)**	Statements 1 and 2 are correct. Statement 3 is wrong: POCSO is with the **Ministry of Women & Child Development**.
9	**(b)**	EFTA has four members: Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, Switzerland. Denmark and Austria are EU members. Three of the five listed are EFTA members.
10	**(b)**	Statement 1 is wrong: India withdrew from RCEP in 2019. Statements 2 and 3 are correct.

Sources

- IMD press release on monsoon withdrawal (15 Oct 2026)
- Andhra Pradesh Revenue (Disaster Management) Dept drought order (1 Oct 2026), as reported by Vajiram & Ravi, South Matters and TheNewsMinute
- Down To Earth (India Drought Monitor)
- MoSPI CPI press release for September 2026 (12 Oct 2026)
- RBI MPC statement and minutes (Oct 2026), as reported by SCC Online and PSU Connect
- Department of Economic Affairs inflation target notification (25 Mar 2026)
- Supreme Court judgment in *Just Rights for Children Alliance v. S. Harish* (15 Oct 2026), as reported by LiveLaw and Bar & Bench
- Supreme Court judgment in *Rajkumar Madki v. Dr. Shailendra Beldale* (16 Oct 2026), as reported by LiveLaw
- India–New Zealand FTA coverage from the Ministry of Commerce & Industry, Taxmann and Law.asia
- RBI Act, 1934
- DPDP Act, 2023
- POCSO Act, 2012
- Manual for Drought Management (2016, updated 2020)

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